

Chapter 1 | Summary Writing

GCE O-Level English Language (Syllabus 1184) | Paper 2, Section C | 15 Marks | About 80 Words

Master Paraphrasing Framework: CAPS

Section A — At a Glance

Paper & section	Paper 2, Section C (Text 4, non-narrative)
Marks	15 marks (15 of 50 in Paper 2): 8 content (1 per point) + 7 language
Time	Approximately 25–30 minutes (commonly recommended in practice)
Length	About 80 words as a single connected paragraph
Word count	Introductory words are given and excluded from your count
Tolerance	Minor overruns (82–85 words) are unlikely to be penalised

Note: Exact marking procedures are confidential; the above reflects publicly available syllabus information and common practice.

Section B — The Six-Step Process

Work through the six steps below in order. Steps 1–3 and 5–6 are process steps that secure the 8 content marks. Step 4 is where the 7 language marks are won or lost — that is where CAPS applies.

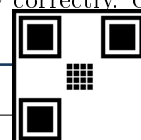
Question Type 1: Single-Part Summary

Technique: Identify the designated paragraphs, hunt for the required number of content points, paraphrase each point using the CAPS framework, then write up as a single connected paragraph within the word limit.

- Step 1. Read the question.** Circle the topic. Bracket the paragraph range. Note whether the question has one part or two parts.
- Step 2. Hunt for points.** Read only the designated paragraphs. Underline each relevant point and number it in the margin. Aim for 9–10 points (you need 8; extras are insurance).
- Step 3. Sort (if two parts).** For two-part questions, draw a line between the points belonging to each half. Plan to split your approximately 80 words roughly evenly.
- Step 4. Paraphrase using CAPS.** Write a paraphrased version (approximately 10 words) beside each numbered point in the margin. Apply at least one CAPS technique per point.
- Step 5. Write up.** Copy the given introductory words. Join your paraphrased points into one flowing paragraph using connectors. For two-part questions, insert a transition between the two halves.
- Step 6. Check the word count.** Count every word after the introductory words. Over approximately 80? Cut filler words or merge overlapping points. Under 70? You have likely missed a point — return to Step 2.

Where the Marks Really Are

Steps 1–3 and 5–6 are procedural and secure your **8 content marks**. **Step 4 is where you win or lose the 7 language marks**. Copying the passage word-for-word limits your language mark to Band 1–2 (maximum 2/7), regardless of how many content points you identify correctly. CAPS is the framework that lifts your language mark to Band 7.



Section C — The CAPS Framework

CAPS is what you use in Step 4. The order matters: perform the structural moves first (**C**, **A**, **P**) and save word swaps (**S**) for last. The band descriptors reward “own words and **structures**” — changing structure demonstrates more understanding than simply replacing synonyms. Every content point requires at least one CAPS move.

Combine & Condense • Alter Word Class •
Purpose Sentence Structure • Swap Words

C — Combine & Condense

Technique: Take two or more related points from the passage and write them as a single, tighter sentence, either by joining clauses with a conjunction or by replacing a list of specific examples with the category they belong to.

Why it works: The passage often presents two points that share a subject. Fusing them into one sentence serves the “well organised ideas” criterion and frees words so you can fit nine points within approximately 80 words. Each successful combine saves 5–10 words. Generalisation (replacing specific examples with a category term) achieves the same compression.

How to apply:

- During Step 2, look for points that appear side by side and share a subject.
- Use *and* for equal ideas, *while* for simultaneous actions, *as well as* for secondary details, *which* to attach a relative clause.
- For generalisation, ask: what category do these specific examples belong to?
- Target: combine at least 2–3 pairs per summary.

Band descriptor link: Improves “Organisation of ideas” (Band 5–7).

Joining with a conjunction

Before: “They are fast. They are agile.”

After: “They are fast and agile.”

Generalising specific examples

Before: “Roses, tulips, and sunflowers are planted along the walkway.”

After: “Various flowers are planted along the walkway.”

A — Alter Word Class

Technique: Take a key word from the passage and change its grammatical class — for example, turn a noun into a verb or an adjective into a noun. The rest of the sentence must restructure around it.

Why it works: Once you change a word's grammatical class, you cannot reconstruct the original sentence — you must rebuild from scratch. This is what examiners mean by “use of own structures.”

Common conversions:

- Noun → Verb: *destruction* → *destroy*
- Adjective → Noun: *beautiful* → *beauty*
- Verb → Noun: *improve* → *improvement*
- Adjective → Adverb: *rapid* → *rapidly*

How to apply: Look for action nouns ending in *-tion*, *-ment*, *-ness*, or *-ity* and convert them into verbs. One word-class change forces the whole sentence to shift.

Band descriptor link: Shows “Successful use of own structures” (Band 7).

Noun → Verb

Before: “The destruction of habitats is a major concern.”

After: “Habitats are being destroyed, which is a major concern.”

Verb → Noun

Before: “They improved the facilities significantly.”

After: “Significant improvements were made to the facilities.”

P — rePurpose Sentence Structure

Technique: Keep all the content words but rearrange how the sentence is built: reorder the clauses, change what the sentence starts with, or flip between active and passive voice.

Why it works: This is the safest move because no words are replaced — meaning cannot be distorted. Active-to-passive (or the reverse) shifts the focus. Use active voice to save words; use passive voice when the doer is unimportant.

How to apply:

- Ask: can I start this sentence with a different element?
- If the passage says “Because of X, Y happened,” try “Y happened due to X.”
- Passive → active saves 1–2 words; active → passive adds 1–2 words. Use strategically at Step 6 to adjust your word count.

Band descriptor link: Demonstrates “Sustained and successful use of own structures” (Band 7).

Reorder clauses

Before: “Because it rained heavily, the match was cancelled.”

After: “The match was cancelled due to heavy rain.”

Active → Passive

Before: “Storms damaged the roads.”

After: “The roads were damaged by storms.”

S — Swap Words

Technique: Replace key words with synonyms, or use the opposite word with a negation when no suitable synonym is available.

Why it works: Synonym replacement is the minimum requirement for all bands above zero. Do **not** swap technical terms that have no true synonym (e.g., *carbon dioxide* remains *carbon dioxide*).

Common swaps: *reduce* → *lessen* / *decrease* / *cut* | *important* → *significant* / *crucial* | *create* → *generate* / *produce* | *help* → *assist* / *support* / *aid*

Antonym + Negation (escape hatch): When no synonym comes to mind, flip to the opposite and add a negative. *Rare* becomes *not common*. *Failed* becomes *did not succeed*. This is a last resort — if in doubt, leave the word unchanged and use **A** or **P** instead.

Band descriptor link: Prevents “Lifting” — minimum requirement for all bands above zero.

Synonym replacement

Before: “Dangerous tasks in extreme environments.”

After: “Hazardous jobs in harsh conditions.”

Antonym + negation

Before: “Robots rarely malfunction during operations.”

After: “Robots do not often break down during operations.”

Section D — CAPS Quick-Reference Table**Summary of the CAPS Framework**

Move	What You Do	When to Use It & Effect on Word Count
C	Join two related points into one sentence; or replace a list of specifics with a category term.	When 2+ points share the same subject, or the passage lists specific examples. <i>Effect: saves 5–10 words per combine.</i>
A	Change a word’s grammatical class (e.g. noun → verb, or adjective → noun).	When the passage has action nouns (<i>-tion</i> , <i>-ment</i> , <i>-ness</i>) or strong verbs to nominalise. <i>Effect: neutral; forces full sentence reconstruction.</i>
P	Reorder clauses; change the sentence opener; or flip between active and passive voice.	When you need structural variety without risking a change in meaning. <i>Effect: active saves 1–2 words; passive adds 1–2 words.</i>
S	Replace key words with synonyms; or use the antonym with a negation as a last resort.	On every content point — this is the minimum requirement for all bands above zero. <i>Effect: neutral.</i>

Section E — What the Examiner Is Looking For

The following band descriptors are taken from the SEAB Syllabus 1184 (p. 10). CAPS maps directly onto both criteria: “own words” is addressed by **S** and **A**; “structures” and “organisation” are addressed by **C**, **A**, and **P**.

Language Mark Band Descriptors (SEAB Syllabus 1184)

Marks	Descriptor
7	Sustained and successful use of own words and structures; consistently well organised ideas which convey the meaning of the text clearly and precisely.
5–6	Frequent and usually appropriate use of own words and structures; mostly well organised ideas which convey the meaning of the text clearly.
3–4	Some use of own words and structures; some attempts at organising ideas to convey the meaning of the text.
1–2	Occasional attempts at use of own words and/or structures; attempts at conveying the meaning of the text.
0	No creditable response.

Note: The band descriptors do not explicitly state that verbatim copying caps a response at Band 1–2. However, Band 3–4 requires “some use of own words” and Band 5–6 requires “frequent” use — verbatim copying fails these criteria by definition.

Section F — Two-Part Questions

Two-part questions follow exactly the same six-step process as single-part questions, with one additional action in Step 5.

Question Type 2: Two-Part Summary

Technique: Identify which paragraph covers each part, sort your points accordingly, apply CAPS to each point, then insert a transition sentence between the two halves when writing up.

Additional actions for two-part questions:

- Step 1 (Read):** Note which paragraph covers Part A and which covers Part B. Write “A” and “B” in the margin before reading.
- Step 3 (Sort):** Draw a physical line across your notes between the Part A and Part B points. Plan approximately 40 words for each half.
- Step 5 (Write):** After writing your Part A sentences, insert a transition sentence before beginning Part B. A missing transition costs marks under the “organisation of ideas” criterion.

Selecting the Correct Transition

Type of Contrast	Use This Transition
Benefits vs. drawbacks	However, / Despite these advantages, / In contrast,
Past vs. present	Today, however, / In recent years, / Since then,
One group vs. another	For [Group B], however, / On the other hand,

One transition is sufficient. Do not insert a second transition mid-paragraph. After the transition, continue connecting Part B points with standard adding connectors.

Connectors for Step 5

Adding Points	Contrasting (Two-Part)	Cause / Effect
Additionally	However	As a result
Furthermore	In contrast	Consequently
Moreover	On the other hand	Therefore
Also	Conversely	Thus
Besides this	Nevertheless	This leads to

Section G — What Goes Wrong

Common Mistakes and Their Consequences

Mistake	Consequence
Lifting phrases directly from the passage	Language mark limited to Band 1–2 (maximum 2/7)
Exceeding the approximately 80-word limit	Content beyond the limit risks not being credited
Using points from wrong paragraphs	Those points receive zero marks
Over-swapping synonyms (distorting meaning)	Content mark withheld for that point
Writing in bullet points or note form	Fails “well organised ideas” criterion
Adding own opinions or examples	No marks for information not in the passage
Forgetting to use the introductory words	May lose marks for organisation
Spending more than 30 minutes	Less time for remaining Section C questions (10 marks)

PUT YOUR CAPS ON

Combine & Condense + Alter Word Class + Purpose Sentence Structure + Swap Words
4 techniques. 9 moves. 7 language marks. 15/15.

Chapter 2 | CAPS in Action — Worked Practice

Section A — Demonstration: Urban Farming

The following walkthrough demonstrates how to apply the full six-step process to a sample passage. Study the point-by-point table carefully — it shows the reasoning behind each technique choice.

Sample Passage

Paragraph 6: Urban farms have become increasingly popular in cities around the world. In Singapore, rooftop gardens help to reduce the country's reliance on imported food, which currently accounts for more than 90 per cent of the nation's food supply. These farms also lower transportation costs because produce does not need to be shipped over long distances. In addition, growing food locally means that vegetables and fruits reach consumers while they are still fresh, rather than wilting during lengthy journeys. Urban farms also create employment opportunities for residents who may otherwise struggle to find work.

Paragraph 7: Beyond food production, urban farms serve important environmental functions. Plants on rooftops absorb carbon dioxide and release oxygen, improving air quality in densely built-up areas. The soil and vegetation also act as natural insulation, keeping buildings cooler and reducing the energy needed for air-conditioning. Furthermore, urban farms provide green spaces where city dwellers can relax, learn about agriculture, and build a sense of community with their neighbours.

The Question: Summarise the benefits of urban farms for city residents. Use only information from Paragraphs 6 and 7.

Begin your summary: "Urban farms benefit city residents because they..."

Step 4 — CAPS Applied, Point by Point

Pt	Original (from passage)	CAPS'd Paraphrase	Techniques
1	reduce the country's reliance on imported food	lessen dependence on food imports	<i>S</i>
2	lower transportation costs; produce not shipped over long distances	cut transport expenses as produce no longer travels far	<i>S + C</i>
3	vegetables and fruits reach consumers while still fresh	locally grown food reaches consumers in a fresher state	<i>A + S</i>
4	create employment opportunities for residents	generate employment for local residents	<i>S + C</i>
5	absorb CO ₂ and release O ₂ , improving air quality	enhance air quality by absorbing CO ₂	<i>A + C</i>
6	act as natural insulation; reducing energy for air-conditioning	insulate buildings, lowering energy needed for cooling	<i>A + S</i>
7	provide green spaces where city dwellers can relax	offer recreational green areas	<i>S</i>
8	learn about agriculture	learn about farming	<i>S</i>
9	build a sense of community with their neighbours	strengthen bonds within their neighbourhood	<i>S + C</i>

Model Summary

Urban farms benefit city residents because they lessen dependence on food imports and cut transport expenses as produce no longer needs to travel long distances. Additionally, locally grown food reaches consumers in a fresher state, and the farms generate employment for local residents. They also enhance air quality by absorbing carbon dioxide, while insulating buildings to lower the energy needed for cooling. Furthermore, these farms offer recreational green areas where residents can learn about farming and strengthen bonds within their neighbourhood. [74 words]

CAPS Audit: S on all 9 points. C on points 1–2, 4–6, and 9. A on points 3, 5, and 6. P was not required — active voice was the shorter option throughout. 74 words, 9 content points, Band 7 language.

Section B — Practice Question 1 — Hawker Culture and Food Heritage

Paragraph 6: Singapore’s hawker centres have long been more than places to eat. They serve as communal spaces where people from different backgrounds gather, share tables with strangers, and engage in casual conversation. This mixing of communities has helped to strengthen social cohesion in a country where racial and religious diversity could otherwise lead to division. Hawker centres also preserve culinary traditions that might otherwise be lost — dishes passed down through generations remain affordable and accessible to all income groups, not just those who can afford restaurant prices. In 2020, Singapore’s hawker culture was inscribed on UNESCO’s Representative List of the Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity, formally recognising its cultural significance.

Paragraph 7: However, the hawker trade faces serious challenges. Many experienced hawkers are ageing, and younger Singaporeans show little interest in taking over the stalls due to long working hours and modest earnings. Training programmes run by government agencies have attracted some new entrants, but the dropout rate remains high because the physical demands of the work are considerable. Beyond succession, rising costs also threaten the trade. The prices of ingredients and rental of stall spaces have increased steadily, squeezing the profit margins of hawkers who are reluctant to raise prices for fear of losing their regular customers.

The Question: Using Paragraphs 6 and 7, write a summary of the value of hawker centres to Singapore society and the difficulties faced by the hawker trade.

Begin your summary: “Hawker centres are valuable to Singapore society because...”

Steps 1–3: Reading and Sorting Points

Teacher Commentary

Step 1. Two parts: Part A is the value of hawker centres (Paragraph 6); Part B is the difficulties (Paragraph 7). Circle *value* and *difficulties*. The introductory words are given — do not count them.

Step 2. Paragraph 6 (Part A) contains five points: (1) people from different backgrounds gather together; (2) this mixing strengthens social cohesion; (3) traditional dishes are preserved; (4) these dishes stay affordable across income groups; (5) hawker culture gained UNESCO recognition.

Step 3. Paragraph 7 (Part B) contains five more: (6) hawkers are ageing and younger people are reluctant to take over; (7) long hours and low pay deter new entrants; (8) training has high dropout rates due to physical demands; (9) ingredient and rental costs have risen; (10) hawkers are afraid to raise prices for fear of losing customers. Draw a line between Part A and Part B points. Aim for approximately 40 words each.

Step 4: CAPS Applied, Point by Point

Pt	Original (from passage)	CAPS'd Paraphrase	Techniques
1	people from different backgrounds gather, share tables, and engage in conversation	individuals of diverse backgrounds mingle and converse	$S + C$
2	strengthen social cohesion; diversity could otherwise lead to division	foster unity in a racially and religiously diverse nation	$S + A + C$
3	preserve culinary traditions; dishes passed down through generations	safeguard traditional recipes handed down across generations	$S + C$
4	remain affordable and accessible to all income groups	remain within reach of people across all economic backgrounds	$S + A + C$
5	formally recognised its cultural significance (UNESCO)	received international recognition for its cultural value	$S + P$
6	ageing hawkers; younger people show little interest in taking over	ageing hawkers struggle to find younger successors	$A + C + S$
7	long working hours and modest earnings	demanding hours and low income	S
8	dropout rate high because physical demands are considerable	many trainees leave due to the physically strenuous nature of the work	$S + P$
9	prices of ingredients and rental of stall spaces have increased steadily	rising ingredient and rental costs have grown steadily	$A + C$
10	reluctant to raise prices for fear of losing regular customers	hawkers hesitate to charge more, fearing the loss of loyal patrons	$S + P$

Steps 5–6: Writing and Checking**Model Summary**

Hawker centres are valuable to Singapore society because they allow individuals of diverse backgrounds to mingle and converse, fostering unity in a racially and religiously diverse nation. They also safeguard traditional recipes handed down across generations, keeping them within reach of people across all economic backgrounds. Moreover, hawker culture has received international recognition for its cultural value. However, the hawker trade faces significant difficulties. Ageing hawkers struggle to find younger successors, as the work involves demanding hours and low income. Although training programmes exist, many trainees leave due to the physically strenuous nature of the work. Additionally, rising ingredient and rental costs have grown steadily, yet hawkers hesitate to charge more, fearing the loss of loyal patrons. **[79 words]**

Step 6 Check. 79 words — on target. All 10 content points included. The transition “However, the hawker trade faces significant difficulties” marks the shift cleanly. CAPS audit: S on all 10 points; C on points 1, 2, 3, 4, 6, 9; A on points 2, 6, 9; P on points 5 and 8. Target band: 7/7 language.

Section C — Practice Question 2 — Screen Time and Young People

Paragraph 5: The widespread use of smartphones and digital devices among young people has brought measurable advantages to their daily lives. Students can access vast amounts of educational content instantaneously, allowing them to research topics, watch instructional videos, and practise skills at their own pace and at any time of day. Social media platforms enable young people to maintain friendships across geographical distances, reducing the isolation that might otherwise accompany relocation or study abroad. Furthermore, digital literacy — the ability to navigate, evaluate, and create content online — has become an essential skill in the modern workforce, and early exposure to technology helps young people develop this competency ahead of their peers.

Paragraph 6: Despite these benefits, excessive screen time poses well-documented risks to young people's wellbeing. Prolonged use of devices, particularly in the hours before sleep, disrupts the body's production of melatonin, a hormone that regulates the sleep cycle. Insufficient sleep, in turn, impairs concentration, mood, and academic performance. Mental health professionals have also noted a correlation between heavy social media use and increased rates of anxiety and depression among teenagers, partly because constant comparison with others' curated online images can erode self-esteem. Physically, sustained periods of looking at screens contribute to eye strain and a sedentary lifestyle, both of which carry long-term health consequences.

The Question: Using Paragraphs 5 and 6, write a summary of the benefits of digital devices for young people and the risks of excessive screen time.

Begin your summary: "Digital devices benefit young people because..."

Steps 1–3: Reading and Sorting Points

Teacher Commentary

Step 1. Two parts. Part A: benefits of digital devices (Paragraph 5). Part B: risks of excessive screen time (Paragraph 6). Circle *benefits* and *risks*. Do not count the introductory words.

Step 2. Paragraph 5 (Part A) contains five points: (1) students can access educational content instantly; (2) they can learn at their own pace and at any time; (3) social media helps maintain friendships across distances; (4) this reduces isolation from relocation or study abroad; (5) early technology use builds digital literacy, a key workplace skill.

Step 3. Paragraph 6 (Part B) contains five more: (6) screen time before sleep disrupts melatonin; (7) poor sleep impairs concentration, mood, and academic performance; (8) heavy social media use is linked to anxiety and depression; (9) comparing oneself to others online erodes self-esteem; (10) screens cause eye strain and a sedentary lifestyle. Draw a line between the two sets of points.

Step 4: CAPS Applied, Point by Point

Note: Points 6 and 7 are combined below — a single C move that saves approximately eight words.

Pt	Original (from passage)	CAPS'd Paraphrase	Techniques
1	access vast amounts of educational content instantaneously	obtain a wide range of learning material immediately	<i>S</i>
2	research topics, watch videos, and practise skills at their own pace	study independently at any hour	<i>C + S</i>
3	enable young people to maintain friendships across geographical distances	allow them to sustain friendships across distances	<i>S + A</i>
4	reducing isolation that might accompany relocation or study abroad	preventing the loneliness that may come with moving away from home	<i>S</i>
5	digital literacy — essential skill in modern workforce; early exposure helps	early technology use builds digital skills valued in today's workplace	<i>A + C + S</i>
6+7	prolonged device use before sleep disrupts melatonin; sleep then impairs concentration, mood, academic performance	excessive screen time before bed disturbs sleep, harming concentration, mood, and school results	<i>C + S + P</i>
8	correlation between heavy social media use and increased anxiety and depression	intensive social media use is linked to higher levels of anxiety and depression	<i>A + S</i>
9	constant comparison with others' curated images can erode self-esteem	comparing oneself unfavourably to others' images damages one's confidence	<i>P + S</i>
10	eye strain and a sedentary lifestyle; long-term health consequences	physical health problems, including eye damage and inactivity	<i>C + S</i>

Steps 5–6: Writing and Checking**Model Summary**

Digital devices benefit young people because they allow students to obtain a wide range of learning material immediately and study independently at any hour. Online platforms enable them to sustain friendships across distances, preventing the loneliness that may come with moving away from home. Additionally, early technology use builds digital skills valued in today's workplace. However, excessive screen time carries serious risks. Using devices before bed disturbs sleep, harming concentration, mood, and school results. Intensive social media use is also linked to higher levels of anxiety and depression, as comparing oneself unfavourably to others' images damages one's confidence. Furthermore, screens contribute to physical health problems, including eye damage and inactivity. **[80 words]**

Step 6 Check. Exactly 80 words. Part A has 5 points; Part B has 5 (with points 6 and 7 merged into one sentence). The transition "However, excessive screen time carries serious risks" marks the shift cleanly. CAPS audit: S on all 9 point units; C on points 2, 5, 6+7, and 10; A on points 5 and 8; P on points 6+7 and 9. Target band: 7/7 language.

1. *(Single-part)* A passage states that exercise reduces the risk of heart disease, improves mental health, and helps maintain a healthy weight. It adds that regular exercise also strengthens bones and builds social connections. Summarise the benefits of exercise. Begin: “Exercise is beneficial because. . .”
2. *(Single-part)* A passage explains that electric vehicles produce no direct emissions, reduce noise pollution, and have lower running costs than petrol cars. The passage also notes that they rely on renewable energy sources. Summarise why electric vehicles are environmentally and economically preferable. Begin: “Electric vehicles are preferable because. . .”
3. *(Two-part)* A passage describes how recycling conserves natural resources and reduces landfill waste. A second paragraph explains that many households do not recycle due to inconvenience and lack of knowledge. Summarise the benefits of recycling and the reasons households do not recycle. Begin: “Recycling is beneficial because. . .”
4. *(Two-part)* A passage about public libraries explains that they provide free access to books and internet services, and that they serve as safe, quiet study spaces. A second paragraph notes that libraries face challenges from falling visitor numbers and reduced funding. Summarise the value of public libraries and the difficulties they face. Begin: “Public libraries are valuable because. . .”
5. *(CAPS revision)* Paraphrase the following sentence using at least two different CAPS techniques. Identify the technique used for each change.
“The government’s introduction of stricter regulations has led to a significant reduction in air pollution levels across the country.”